

Leelanau Cellars Quick Facts for Tasting Room Staff



Our Story

- **Founded in 1974 by the Jacobson family and Charles Kalchik** when they planted their first vines at their Leelanau County cherry orchard, making it **one of the oldest wineries in northern Michigan**.
- **Still family-owned by the Jacobson family today**, with Bob Jacobson owning the winery as President and CEO. His father, Mike, founded Leelanau Cellars.
- **Today, we are the largest distributor of wine in the state and No. 2 distributor in the Midwest**, distributing more than 300,000 cases to 43 different states every year.
 - o As a result, a lot of people recognize Leelanau Cellars by our wines in their local wine aisle, including:
 - **Witches Brew:** Distributed in 44 different states. Started in 1997. Brand added Spiced Apple and Pumpkin Spice and has been featured on Today Show.
 - **Winter White:** Recognized for the blue bottle. It's the #1 white wine in this region. Available in bubbly as well. Started in 1986.
 - We also once offered Winter White Chills, which are now just called "Chill," with four different flavors.
 - **Great Lakes Red:** Best-selling concord grape wine in Michigan. "Boozy grape juice." Started in 2003.
 - **Farm Fresh:** Started in 2019 as a fruit wine brand. Added Fruit Moscatos in 2020 and Fruit Bubbly Moscatos in 2021.
 - **Country Crush** and **Lakeshore Farms** are our other fruit wine brands, which you can find on our website.
 - **Other wines in stores:** Seasonal Series (Autumn Harvest, Winter White, Spring Splendor, Summer Sunset), Red Sangria, White Sangria, Sweet Red, Sleeping Bear Red, Lakeshore Collection (4 wines)
- **Award-winning Estate Wines:** The majority of estate wines have had a vintage earn an award in the San Francisco Chronicle Wine Competition, the largest wine competition in North America (All awards on our website).



About the Region: Traverse City Wine Country

- **Cool-climate, maritime region** influenced by Lake Michigan.
- **Short growing season** with spring and fall frost risk.
- **Well-drained sandy loam soils**, ideal for viticulture.
- **Lake Michigan buffers temperature** → cooler summer days, warmer winters.
- **Snow cover insulates vines** in winter, aiding survival of cold-tender varieties.



Growing Conditions

- **Growing Degree Days (GDD):** Ranges from 1,500 to 2,400; avg ~2,000. *See pg. 2 for highlighted description
 - **No need for irrigation** — rainfall is sufficient.
 - **Cool fall temps = complex flavors**, especially in whites.
 - **Frosts & winterkill** can affect yields and vine health.
 - **Canopy management, cover crops, and compost** used to promote soil and vine health.
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Our Vineyard Sites (68.5 total acres)

Site	Key Features	# of Vineyards*
Omena	Elevated, forest-sheltered, sandy loam, southern aspect	17
M204	Hilly, open, windy, excellent air and moisture drainage	18
Pleasant Hill	Warm afternoon sun, heavier soil in places	7
Hilltop	Winery site, even terrain, rich silt soils on north side	1 (trial)

* Vineyard defined by set of vines distinct from other sets by time (year of planting), type (variety and/or root stock), or space (location within a site). Ex. Riesling planted at the same time and in the same area is one vineyard. Riesling planted at same time at two different parts of the site are two vineyards. Riesling planted at different times at the same part of the site are two vineyards.



Grape Varieties Grown

Variety	Type	Acreage	Location(s)	Notes
Chardonnay	White (Vinifera)	3.9 acres	Omena (2 vineyards)	Cold-hardy, mid-season ripener
Gewürztraminer	White (Vinifera)	2.5 acres	M204 (2 vineyards)	Floral, spicy, aromatic, early ripening
Pinot Gris	White (Vinifera)	21.8 acres	Omena (4.0), M204 (7.8), Pleasant Hill (10.0)	Early ripener, tight clusters, must be carefully managed
Riesling	White (Vinifera)	16.5 acres	Omena (4.7), M204 (11.8)	Cold-hardy, late-season harvest, tight clusters
Sauvignon Blanc	White (Vinifera)	0.7 acres	M204	Cold-tender, early ripener, bright flavors
Cabernet Franc	Red (Vinifera)	1.1 acres	Omena	Cold-hardy red, structured and tannic
Cabernet Sauvignon	Red (Vinifera)	0.9 acres	Omena	Late ripener, less frost risk due to late bud break
Merlot	Red (Vinifera)	4.2 acres	Omena (2.6), M204 (1.6)	Mid-late ripener, Bordeaux variety
Pinot Noir	Red (Vinifera)	4.5 acres	Omena (2.3), M204 (2.2)	Early ripener, sometimes harvested for Rosé
Vignoles	White (Hybrid)	3.1 acres	Omena	Very cold-hardy, late bud break, can develop Noble Rot
Baco Noir	Red (Hybrid)	9.3 acres	Omena (1.9), Pleasant Hill (7.4)	First to ripen, rich in flavor and color

White Hybrids in Hilltop Trial: Cayuga White, Frontenac Gris, La Crescent, Valvin Muscat, Traminette, Vignoles

Red Hybrids in Hilltop Trial: Frontenac, Marquette

Coming Soon: In 2022, our oldest vineyard of Baco Noir was removed, with that vintage now called Baco Noir: The End. In the spring of 2026, Sauvignon Blanc will fill that spot in our Pleasant Hill vineyard. That new vineyard will likely be able to produce its first vintage of wine in 2029.



Vintage Vineyard Summaries

2019

- Harsh winter (-14°F in March) caused severe winterkill.
- Low yields due to crop loss and labor shortages.

- Cold, wet growing season with low heat accumulation.

2020

- Average heat, very wet.
- Yields slightly below average.
- Early frost in late September triggered early leaf senescence, though not rapid.

2021

- Warm, dry (excluding two major summer rainstorms).
- Yields 7–10% below average.
- Excellent sugars (20–24 °Brix), slightly elevated acids.

2022

- Average warmth and rainfall (except wet spring and late fall).
- High yields with solid sugar development.
- Slightly elevated acids contribute to good wine structure.

2023

- High-quality yields, low winterkill.
- Season started cool, warmed significantly late in the year.
- Good ripeness with prominent fruit and acidity—wines expected to have strong flavor and structure.

2024

- Mild winter, no crop loss.
- High temperatures and early phenology stages.
- Drought from August–October resulted in concentrated flavors and excellent quality. High sugar, relatively low acidity
- **Sauvignon Blanc 2024** received early leaf pulling (pre-bloom) to develop tropical fruit notes; hand-harvested.